music? What was he doing? "These were all questions reflected at myself and I think that's how I took the untrodden path, so to speak. I didn't have anybody who I could follow, which I think was the greatest gift. If I did, I don't know whether I would have been as free," he says.

Krishna has partnered with individuals and collectives working at the intersections of social change, collaborated and performed with the Jogappas (transgender musicians) and co-conceptualised and performed Karnatik Kattaikuttu, an unusual aesthetic conversation between art forms and communities that belong to two ends of the social spectrum. He also partnered with leading Tamil writer Perumal Murugan to present literature on the 'classical' stage and also brought the poetry of social reformer and philosopher Sree Narayana Guru into the Carnatic fold.

The recipient of several honours, including the Ramon Magsaysay Award, the Indira Gandhi Award for National Integration, the Swathi Sangeetha Puraskaram, the Pasumai Award and the Sangita Kalanidhi early this year, Krishna is in the final stages of penning what he calls "a historical, philosophical, and constitutional book that reflects on the five symbols of India—the anthem, the flag, the emblem, the motto and the Preamble". Rest assured, it will raise some important philosophical and societal questions—just as art should. ■

***—Deepali Dhingra***

*The KNMA Festival will be held at Sunder Nursery, Delhi, from Oct. 9 to 12*

MUSIC ▼

# *India's* Musical Soul

SALIM–SULAIMAN'S *BHOOMI* REIMAGINES INDIA'S **FOLK, CLASSICAL, AND DEVOTIONAL TRADITIONS** TO MAKE THEM CONTEMPORARY

**For centuries, India's music has carried the pulse of its land from village squares to temple courtyards. With *Bhoomi*, composer-producer duo Salim and Sulaiman Merchant have reimagined these traditions, fusing folk, devotional and classical sounds with a contemporary beat. "This season began with Janmashtami," shares Salim. "The first song, 'Dwarika Darbaar', was a celebration of Lord Krishna and the joyous spirit of Dwarka. *Bhoomi* reflects India's diversity: different languages, cultures and devotional traditions." Other early releases include 'Shringaar' (a tribute to Ustad Zakir Hussain, sung by Shankar Mahadevan), 'Sukoon' (a reflective music video with Arijit Singh) and 'Tum Jo Kaho Toh' with Shaan. "'Sukoon' was inspired by a line from Maula Ali: 'Whatever you seek is within you.' It changed my life, and I always wanted to turn it into a song," explains Salim.**

**"Some songs on the album are treasures that must be heard by this generation," says Salim. "Bandishes, ghazals, bhajans, chants"**



Salim and (left) Sulaiman Merchant

**More is on the way, with six upcoming tracks on the duo's YouTube channel. These include 'Jogiya' with Sonu Nigam, a Kashmiri folk song, an Uttarakhandi piece, a ghazal by Hariharan and Prithvi Gandharv, a romantic duet with Papon and Shreya Ghoshal and 'Chal Khediye', a Punjabi track with OAFF, Burrah and Krish Mondal. Salim insists the spirit of *Bhoomi* lies in authenticity: "I follow my heart. Some songs are treasures that must be heard by this generation—bandishes, ghazals, bhajans, chants. Others are new compositions, created with the same reverence."**

**For him, *Bhoomi* is more than a project, it's a community. "I don't like the word 'industry'. I prefer 'community'. The duo hopes to take *Bhoomi* to the live stage. "It's collaboration, love and shared ownership," says Salim, about an album that reflects India's soul. ■**

***—Nikhil Sardana***

***All songs will premiere on their official YouTube channel: @SalimSulaimanMusic***